Feather-Handed Fascists

Surveillance as a Signal of Bureaucratic Loyalty

Pau Grau-Vilalta (EUI) Lorenzo Vicari (LSE) Andrea Xamo (Verona)

2nd Tor Vergata PhD Conference in Economics

November 24, 2025

Preview

We analyse:

- high-level decentralized **bureaucrats** (*prefects*)
- in Fascist Italy (1922-1940),
- who controlled the political police
- and may have a visible **loyalty marker**:
  - some joined the Fascist Party early (*loyalists*)
  - some did not (*careerists*)

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- and **rewards** (office retention).

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Main findings:

- Loyalist prefects $\implies$ $\downarrow$ surveillance ($-$18–22% political-police records, –6/yr)
- Loyalist prefects $\times$ surveillance $\implies$ $\uparrow$ retention in office (additional $+3\%$ per record)

Motivation

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Two ways to see it:

- it is easier for loyalists to set higher effort, so they will (Svolik 2012; Scharpf and Gläßel 2020 in Argentina; Aaskoven and Nyrup 2021 in Nazi Germany)

  → YES

- different costs make effort a signal of loyalty (theory: Montagnes and Wolton 2019; Luo and Zakharov 2025; evidence: Qian and Bai 2024)

  → careerists need to prove themselves, so they set higher effort

  → NO

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Two groups of agents with high or low private loyalty:

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- careerists do not $\rightarrow$ both high and low types

They can set effort ($\rightarrow$ increasing output) at a cost, which is lower for high types,

hoping for a reward (e.g. office retention).

Sketch of Empirical Implication

What happens depends on the rewarding mechanism:

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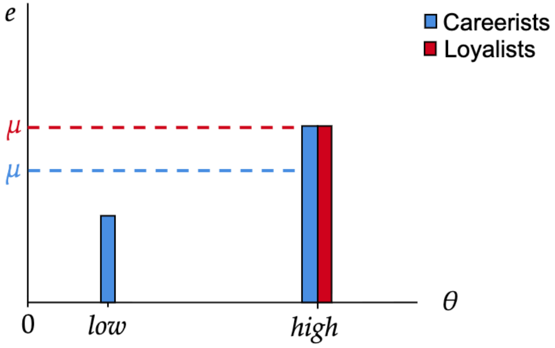

Figure 1: Only effort is rewarded

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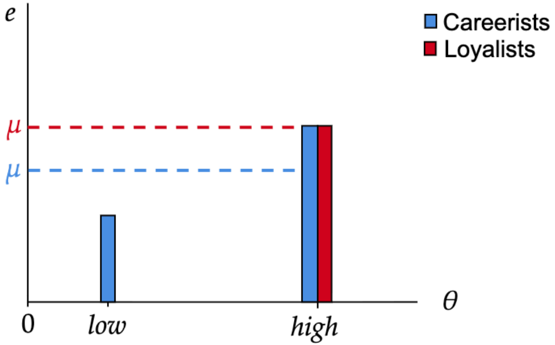

Figure 1: Only effort is rewarded

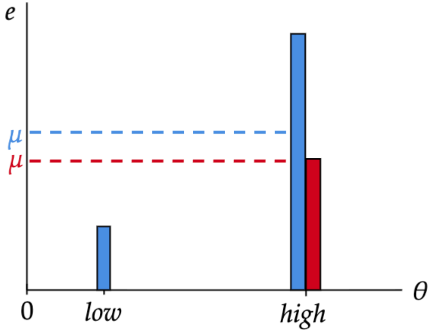

Figure 2: A mix of effort and loyalty is rewarded

Case

History: the Prefect

- Office instituted by Napoleon (avg. mandate length: 2.3 years),
- highest representative of executive power in the province,
- heavily relied on by the regime (more than local party chiefs),
- with vast policing powers:
  - oversaw police chiefs,
  - liaised with the secret police (OVRA),
  - decided on *confino* (see Fontana et al., WP).

The Prefect, as the supreme authority of the State in the Province, must be the sword that descends inexorably.

(Mussolini, Dec 6 1926, in Sergi, *When Mussolini Gave Prefects Licence to Kill*)

History: a Timeline

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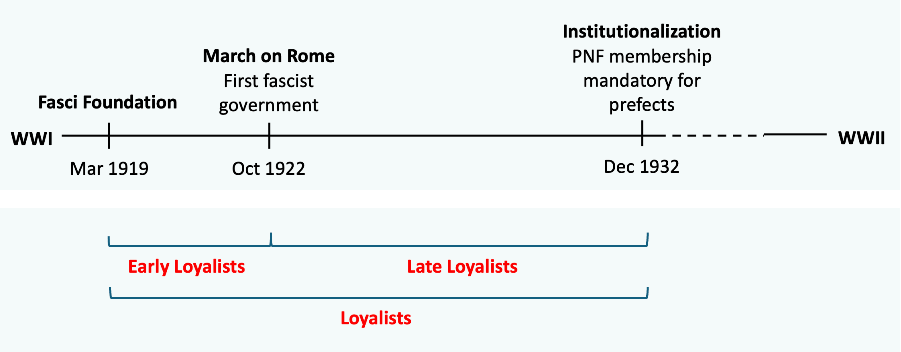

Figure 3: Prefect Loyalty Marker Classification

Data

Digitizations

- OCR'd *prefect biographies* from Cifelli (1999), cross-checking appointments from Missori (1989) $\rightarrow$ 414 prefects, 90 provinces.

d'EUFEMIA nob. ing. Angelo[1]

Nato a Napoli il 16 aprile 1888. Laureato in Ingegneria Civile. Ingegnere. Dirigente dei Sindacati Fascisti (Firenze). Nominato prefetto di 2ª classe il 16 settembre 1927[2] e prefetto di 1ª classe il 14 settembre 1934.

Grand'Ufficiale dell'Ordine della Corona d'Italia. Commendatore dell'Ordine Mauriziano.

Iscritto al P.N.F. dal marzo 1921.

Antemarcia. Brevetto Marcia su Roma. Squadrista. Sciarpa Littorio. Seniore della M.V.S.N. dall'agosto 1938.

Prefetto di Vercelli (settembre 1927 - aprile 1932), Savona (aprile 1932 - luglio 1935), Aosta (luglio 1935 - agosto 1939). A disposizione e incaricato di esercitare le funzioni ispettive (agosto 1939 - febbraio 1940) e dall'agosto 1939 Regio Commissario presso l'Ospedale di S. Maria Nuova in Firenze. Prefetto di Messina (febbraio 1940 - aprile 1943). A disposizione (aprile 1943 - febbraio 1944) con l'incarico di Direttore Generale per i Servizi di Guerra (aprile 1943 - gennaio 1944) e dal gennaio 1944 di Commissario per l'Amministrazione straordinaria dell'Istituto S. Michele di Roma.

Collocato a riposo per ragioni di servizio dal Governo fascista nel febbraio 1944.

Incaricato della Direzione dell'Ufficio Staccato in Roma dei Servizi di Guerra dal 20 febbraio 1944 (R.S.I.)[3].

Digitizations

- OCR'd *prefect biographies* from Cifelli (1999), cross-checking appointments from Missori (1989) $\rightarrow$ 414 prefects, 90 provinces.
- *Individual-level political-police records* from the Political Police Archive (see Panza et al. (2023); Dipoppa & Pezone, WP) $\rightarrow$ almost 100-thousand individuals.

Descriptives: Explanatory Variable

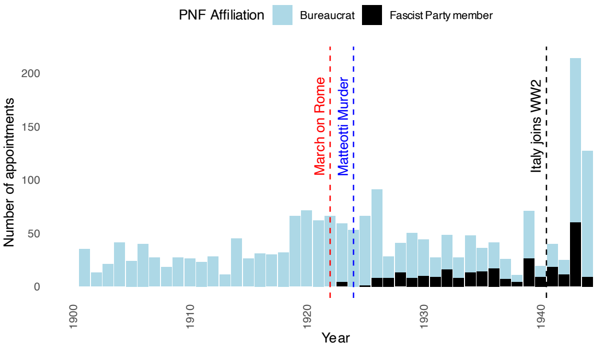

Figure 4: Loyalist Appointments

Descriptives: Outcome Variable

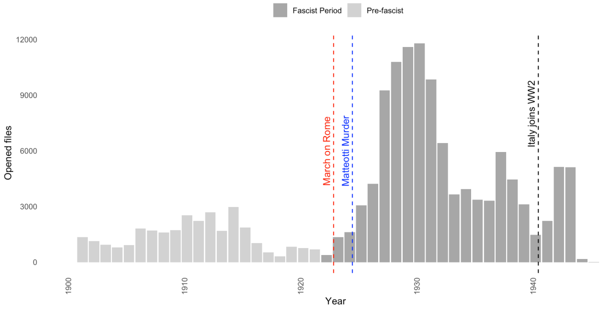

Figure 5: Surveillance Records

Descriptives: Raw Trends

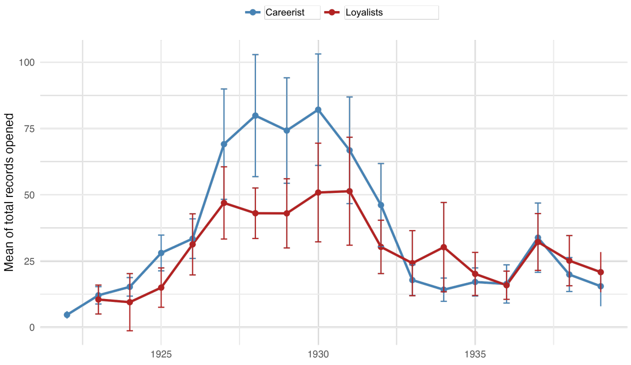

Figure 6: Annual means of records opened each year in provinces with (red) and without (blue) a loyalist prefect in office; bands are 95% CIs.

Empirics

Empirical Strategy

Treatment: a loyalist prefect is assigned to the province (duration-weighted 0–1: share of year)

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Staggered DiD à la de Chaisemartin and D'Haultfœuille (2024), on not-yet-treated.

Accounts for:

- continuous treatment,
- staggered treatment adoption,
- and treatment exit.

Parallel trends violated if loyalists are assigned to locations where opposition is anticipated to weaken.

Staggered DiD - Results

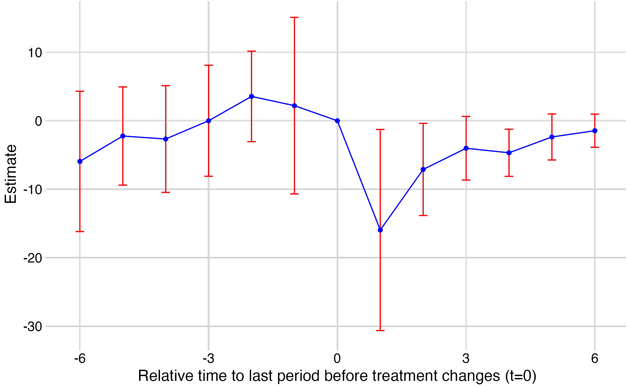

Figure 7: Effect of Receiving any Loyalist as Prefect.

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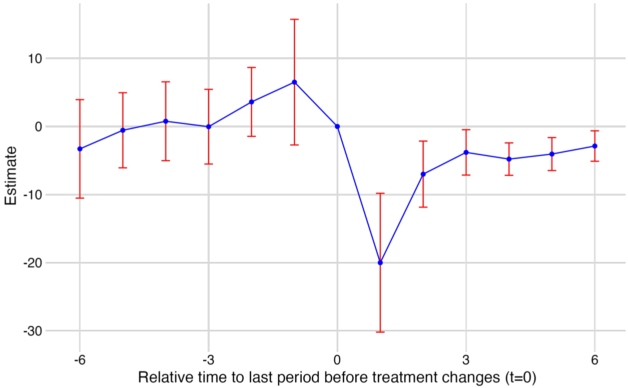

Figure 8: Effect of Receiving an Early Loyalist as Prefect.

We also fit a TWFE or restrict to Complete values.

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  Only significant when the incoming prefect is a loyalist.

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- **Signalling:**
  Careerists put more effort to reveal their loyalty.
  - Careerists go after the usual suspects (empirical implication from Luo and Zakharov 2025).
    Suspects

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  - Careerists are rewarded less per record opened

Signaling: Empirical Implication Sketch

If we assume the total reward (observed - *probability of office retention*) is increasing in:

- effort (observed - *number of records opened*)
- and revealed loyalty (unobserved)

(consistent with Jia, Kudamatsu, and Seim 2015).

Then:

- loyalists always receive the loyalty-based reward
- careerists receive it only if they put a lot of effort

$\implies$ fixing effort, loyalists are rewarded more

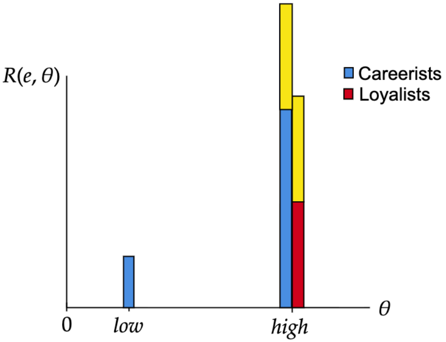

Figure 9: Mixed Reward System Implies Lower Returns to Effort for Careerists

Signaling: Empirical Test

We fit a simple interacted model:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Retain Office}_{i,m} = {} & \beta_1 \text{Records}_{i,m} + \beta_2 \text{Loyalty}_{i,m} \\ & + \beta_3 \text{Records}_{i,m} \times \text{Loyalty}_{i,m} + \phi_i + \gamma_m + \varepsilon_{i,m}\end{aligned}$$

- Prefect i and mandate m
- ϕ_i Province and γ_m Mandate number FE
- OLS and LOGIT

We expect:

- $\beta_1 > 0$: surveillance makes it more likely to be reappointed,
- $\beta_3 > 0$: and more so for early loyalists.

Signalling: Empirical Test

Table 1: Early Members Gain More Job Security from Surveillance

Dependent Variable:	Retain Office					
Model:	(1) OLS	(2) OLS	(3) Logit	(4) OLS	(5) OLS	(6) Logit
Variables						
Records	0.001***	0.001***	0.009***	0.001**	0.001***	0.007***
	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.003)	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.002)
Early Loyalist				-0.088	-0.092	-0.508
				(0.069)	(0.070)	(0.382)
Early Loyalist × Records				0.005***	0.005***	0.029**
				(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.011)
Fixed-effects						
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mandate number		Yes	Yes		Yes	Yes
Fit statistics						
Dependent variable mean	0.599	0.599	0.609	0.599	0.599	0.609
Observations	780	780	767	780	780	767
Adjusted R^2	0.025	0.027		0.031	0.033	
F-test	14.167	1.344		5.067	1.220	

Clustered (Province) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Signalling: Empirical Test

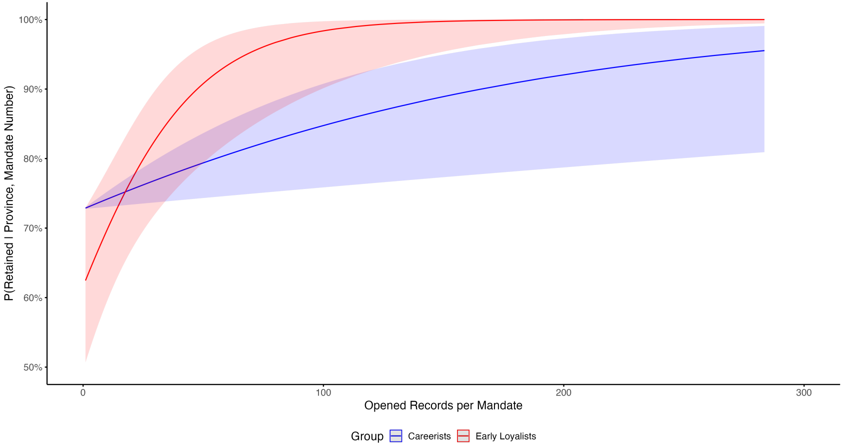

Figure 10: Early Loyalists Gain More Job Security per Record

Takeaways

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The case of surveillance in fascist Italy suggests that:

- appointing loyalists does not necessarily lead to more forceful implementation of controversial policies
- as PNF prefects surveilled the opposition less than their counterparts.
- This seems not to be due to signaling incentives (effort as a costly signal & higher priors of loyalty).

  → evidence of trade-off between loyalty and leverage (Luo and Zakharov, 2025)

  → underscores a facet of the banality of evil (Arendt, 1963)

Thank you!

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Appendix

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Svolik, Milan W. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge Studies in Comparative Politics. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Two-Way Fixed Effects

Table 2: Early Fascists Police Less Relative To Career Administrators

	Number of Police Records Opened			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Voluntary Member	-5.622**		-5.468**	
	(2.480)		(2.687)	
Early Member		-6.845**		-6.284**
		(2.641)		(2.860)
Late Member		2.194		-0.087
		(6.387)		(6.560)
Restricted Sample			✓	✓
Dependent variable mean	31.057	31.057	31.766	31.766
Observations	1,794	1,794	1,412	1,412
Adjusted R^2	0.613	0.614	0.619	0.619
F-test	6.033	5.825	6.348	6.120
Province fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Standard errors are clustered at the province level.

, **, and * correspond to 10, 5, and 1% levels of significance, respectively.*

Back

Complete values

Table 3: Early Fascists Surveil Less Relative To Career Administrators

	Number of Records Opened			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Voluntary Member	-4.741*		-5.356**	
	(2.535)		(2.678)	
Early Member		-6.063**		-6.180**
		(2.716)		(2.849)
Late Member		4.849		1.401
		(6.359)		(6.585)
Restricted Sample			✓	✓
Dependent variable mean	30.877	30.944	31.367	31.450
Observations	1,611	1,597	1,382	1,368
Adjusted R^2	0.610	0.611	0.613	0.613
F-test	6.034	5.843	6.230	6.021
Province fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Standard errors are clustered at the province level.

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Back

Mere Turnover

Table 4: Mere Turnover Does Not Drive the Result

Dependent Variable:	Number of Records Opened			
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
Any Change	-1.632	-1.618	-0.759	-0.809
	(1.553)	(1.546)	(2.202)	(2.206)
Voluntary Member	-5.712**		-5.532**	
	(2.493)		(2.683)	
Early Member		-6.939**		-6.364**
		(2.657)		(2.856)
Late Member		2.009		-0.160
		(6.394)		(6.559)
Restricted Sample			✓	✓
Fixed-effects				
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics				
Dependent variable mean	31.057	31.057	31.766	31.766
Observations	1,794	1,794	1,412	1,412
Adjusted R^2	0.613	0.614	0.618	0.618
F-test	5.815	5.622	6.114	5.903

Clustered (Province) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Back

Mechanism: Competence

Table 5: Early Fascists Police Less Controlling for Competence Proxies

	Number of Records Opened			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Early Member	-7.291**	-6.355**	-6.865**	-6.154**
	(2.791)	(2.665)	(2.638)	(2.930)
Late Member	2.006	1.783	2.515	2.152
	(6.457)	(6.391)	(6.475)	(6.455)
Has a Degree	-2.120			-1.963
	(3.452)			(3.466)
Years of Experience		-0.538		-1.288
		(0.605)		(1.341)
Current Mandate Number			0.583	2.020
			(0.769)	(2.100)
Dependent variable mean	31.057	31.057	31.057	31.057
Observations	1,794	1,794	1,794	1,794
Adjusted R^2	0.613	0.614	0.614	0.616
F-test	5.619	5.637	5.625	5.317
Province fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

, **, and * correspond to 10, 5, and 1% levels of significance, respectively. Standard errors are clustered at the province level.*

Back

Mechanism: Deterrence

That streets are peaceful does not mean there is no violence.

(in Przeworski, 2015, p. 249)

- If early members had a harsh reputation,
- the opposition might go underground once they are appointed,

$\rightarrow$ prefects might surveil less because insurgent activity is reduced.

If this is the case, they might have built that reputation by **opening more records initially** and much less later.

Mechanism: Deterrence

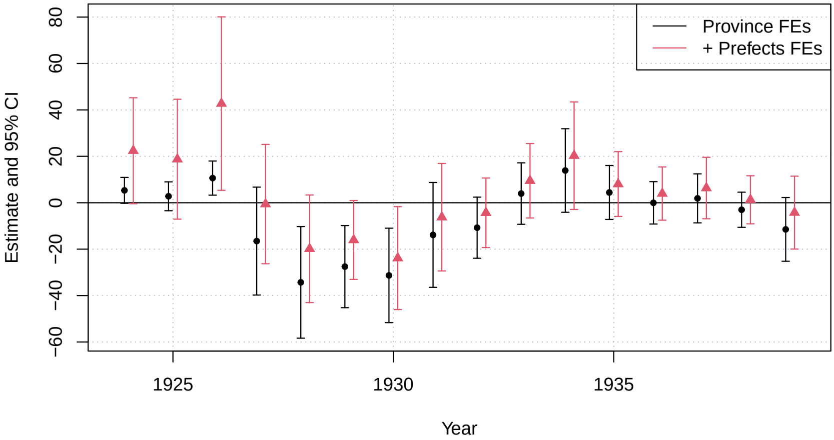

Figure 11: Early Members Building a Harsh Reputation?

Mechanism: Deterrence

Table 6: Early Surveillance Does Not Seem to Build Deterrence

Dependent Variable:	Number of Records Opened							
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Variables								
Early Surveillance	0.369***	0.371***	0.375***	0.384***	0.362***	0.384***	0.362***	0.391***
	(0.107)	(0.103)	(0.111)	(0.100)	(0.117)	(0.105)	(0.119)	(0.099)
Voluntary Member	-9.329***	-8.899**			-8.978***	-8.064**		
	(3.179)	(3.504)			(3.103)	(3.509)		
Early Surveillance × Voluntary Member	0.091	0.163			0.050	0.116		
	(0.213)	(0.198)			(0.201)	(0.186)		
Early Member			-9.443***	-8.966**			-9.209***	-8.229**
			(3.456)	(3.873)			(3.341)	(3.857)
Late Member			-7.276	-5.345			-7.949	-5.666
			(6.025)	(5.619)			(5.907)	(5.252)
Early Surveillance × Early Member			0.074	0.104			0.078	0.095
			(0.245)	(0.249)			(0.246)	(0.254)
Restricted Sample					✓	✓	✓	✓
Fixed-effects								
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mandate Number		Yes		Yes		Yes		Yes
Fit statistics								
Dependent variable mean	32.599	32.599	32.599	32.599	32.401	32.401	32.401	32.401
Observations	567	567	567	567	506	506	506	506
Adjusted R^2	0.570	0.579	0.569	0.578	0.569	0.583	0.568	0.582
F-test	52.757	13.000	39.551	12.048	54.588	13.729	40.951	12.738

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Mechanism: Embeddedness

- More local prefects might surveil more efficiently (Scott, 1998; Mattingly, 2019)
- Yet fascist prefects are not deployed closer to home,
- and embeddedness is not associated with less surveillance

Mechanism: Embeddedness

Table 7: More Local Prefects Do Not Surveil Less

Dependent Variable:	Records Opened					
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Birthplace Distance	-0.003	-0.004	-0.004	-0.005	-0.004	-0.005
	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.006)
Birthplace Distance × Voluntary Member			0.012	0.012		
			(0.009)	(0.009)		
Birthplace Distance × Early Member					0.013	0.012
					(0.009)	(0.009)
Fixed-effects						
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mandate Number		Yes		Yes		Yes
Fit statistics						
Dependent variable mean	30.201	30.201	30.201	30.201	30.201	30.201
Observations	751	751	751	751	751	751
Adjusted R^2	0.485	0.486	0.484	0.486	0.483	0.485
F-test	105.705	9.144	35.344	7.861	26.522	7.340

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Mechanism: Preferential Deployment

- Fascist prefects might be more "upwardly embedded" (Toral, 2024)
- and sent to easier locations,
- but we cannot measure waning opposition.

We assume prefects prefer to be deployed in provinces which are:

- closer to home

  $\rightarrow$ we calculate distance from birthplace,

- more prestigious

  $\rightarrow$ we calculate the likelihood prefects in the province became MPs (in the Liberal Era).

Mechanism: Preferential Deployment

Table 8: Loyalists Are Not Deployed to Better Places

Dependent Variables:	Birthplace Distance				Prestige Score	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Voluntary Member	-17.950	-14.006			0.005	
	(22.068)	(23.416)			(0.006)	
Early Member			-16.620	-12.933		0.001
			(24.546)	(25.834)		(0.006)
Late Member			-26.324	-20.802		0.032^{***}
			(38.702)	(37.602)		(0.007)
Fixed-effects						
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Mandate number		Yes		Yes	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics						
Dependent variable mean	433.264	433.264	433.264	433.264	0.158	0.158
Observations	788	788	788	788	800	800
Adjusted R^2	0.049	0.047	0.047	0.046	0.111	0.111
F-test	18.037	1.634	9.020	1.509	1.565	0.791

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Mechanism: Testable Implications of Signaling

- Luo and Zakharov (2025) predict efficiency-signaling through the targeting of most likely (ethnic) opponents,
- because ethnicity is observable by the dictator.

Mechanism: Testable Implications of Signaling

- Luo and Zakharov (2025) predict efficiency-signaling through the targeting of most likely (ethnic) opponents,
- because ethnicity is observable by the dictator.

- As ethnicity is not relevant in our context, we classify most likely opponents as working-class individuals (low-skilled jobs)
- and check mediation:

Table 9: Early Loyalists effect is entirely mediated by low-skill targets.

Effect	Estimate	95% CI
ACME (indirect)	–7.24	[–11.26 ; –3.73]
ADE (direct)	0.27	[–1.14 ; 1.76]
Total effect	–6.97	[–10.85 ; –3.56]

Notes: Two–equation OLS with province and year fixed effects. ACME = average causal mediation effect; ADE = average direct effect.

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